



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Westminster School at Oak Mountain

School Website: <https://westminsterknights.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Westminster School at Oak Mountain (WSOM) presents a robust classical Christian identity embedded in a covenantal community and reinforced by a clearly stated formation-focused mission. Public materials consistently frame WSOM as a K-12 classical Christian school aligned with Christ-centered theology and a classical heritage, with explicit emphasis on forming wisdom and virtue, not merely delivering information. The curriculum emphasizes the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), with upper-school expectations such as a capstone thesis, and a strong articulation of forming character in tandem with academic rigor. Public materials also foreground active parental partnership and community involvement.

Overall, by the classical rubric, WSOM leans CLASSICAL across most dimensions, with Curriculum and Pedagogy showing notable alignment to classical practice (e.g., grammar/logic/rhetoric, capstone work, theology-inflected formation). Some areas show partial alignment (notably explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language or fully documented Socratic seminar structures on every level within public materials). Based on the rubric and the public materials analyzed here, WSOM earns a CLASSICAL rating overall, with room to strengthen explicit Great Books / Socratic pedagogy and liturgical/community-practice documentation in public channels.

Key contextual notes drawn from the school's public materials and the classical-education rubric:

- Core religious/metaphysical grounding is explicit: WSOM identifies as a gospel-centered, classical Christian school in covenantal relation with Oak Mountain Presbyterian Church (PCA) and foregrounds Christ-centered formation (evidenced in admissions messaging and about pages).
- Formation and virtue are foregrounded as core aims, alongside intellectual growth (e.g., formation vs. information, virtuous aims, and a mission to equip with wisdom, virtue, and eloquence).
- Curriculum signals align with classical priorities: grammar, logic, rhetoric in early stages; capstone work in upper grades; emphasis on a life of learning and the liberal arts; and a theological/affection-focused orientation in the fine-arts and visual-arts content (evident in upper-school philosophy of learning, and art programs stressing beauty as rooted in divine order).
- Parental partnership and community life are foregrounded as core operating principles, with explicit language about partnering with parents as co-teachers and inviting family engagement in the classical project.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence

- Public materials clearly identify WSOM as a gospel-centered, classical Christian school and a ministry of Oak Mountain Presbyterian Church (PCA).
- Admissions messaging emphasizes partnering with Christian families in a covenantal community and a vision of building Christ's kingdom by equipping students with wisdom, virtue, and eloquence; the theological framing is explicit (gospel-centered, Christian formation).
- Visual Arts and fine-arts content reference God as the source of beauty and knowledge and articulate a sacred, theological framing of aesthetic education, tying beauty to divine order and creation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present include: gospel-centered, Christian, theology, covenant, preeminent gospel, wisdom/virtue framed in a sacred context, God as source of beauty, sacred order.
- Negative keywords (e.g., secularism, relativism, value-neutral ethics) do not appear in school-facing materials.
- The Lexicon for this category prioritizes truth/goodness/beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, worship; WSOM materials align with these signals via explicit religious framing and liturgical-theological language in public messaging.

Why this rating

- The school's public-facing materials demonstrate the strongest alignment with religious/metaphysical foundations (explicit Christian framing, theology, covenantal community, gospel-centered formation) without evident secular or value-neutral positioning. This supports a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Cited evidence

- The school is described as a K-12 classical Christian school and ministry of a PCA church.
- The leadership speaks of a thoroughly Christian approach and gospel preeminence in community life.
- Admissions emphasizes gospel-centered, covenantal partnership with families.
- Art content foregrounds aesthetic education rooted in creation and divine source of beauty.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission frames education as formation of wisdom and virtue rather than mere information or job training (formation language appears in the public materials; the admissions messaging emphasizes virtue and wisdom through a classical framework).
- The upper school materials emphasize training in habits of mind and heart for life, not just for tests (tools of learning, habits of heart and mind) and capstone work, signaling formation as the telos of education.
- The mission statement in employment communications positions "wisdom, virtue, and eloquence" as the educational telos and core aims of the school.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, telos, true/good/beautiful (implied through formation and cape of virtue), liberal education (through classical mission framing).
- Negative keywords: references to "career/work readiness" or purely skills-based outcomes are not foregrounded; the explicit formation focus counters such signals.
- The lexicon signals for this category include "formation," "cultivate virtue," "pursuit of truth, goodness, beauty." WSOM's materials map to these signals with formation emphasis and virtue-oriented language.

Why this rating

- WSOM's stated purpose centers on formation, virtue, and wisdom rather than vocational training, aligning with classical aims for human excellence and the pursuit of true/good/beautiful.

Cited evidence

- Public materials describe a gospel-centered classical education within a covenantal framework and formation over mere information.
- Mission language highlights forming heart and mind toward wisdom and virtue across curriculum and community life.
- Upper School messaging emphasizes forming habits of mind and heart and capstone scholarly work, consistent with formation as telos.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Explicitly documented liberal-arts orientation appears via references to grammar, logic, and rhetoric in the lower school, with upper school emphasizing deeper study and a capstone thesis.
- The school presents a classical trajectory (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and a capstone experience in the high school years, signaling alignment with the Trivium and the expectation of mature reasoning and persuasive writing. The site also references the classical heritage and a life of learning in the context of a high school program.
- Public materials discuss “classical” methodology and a vision of education that integrates history and other disciplines in a way consistent with classical education, though explicit Great Books or “Great Conversation” language is not consistently foregrounded on the site. The associated knowledge-base documents (Six Essential Elements) outline Great Books/Great Conversation and Seven Liberal Arts as core concepts (even if not all are explicitly stated on the WSOM site).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric; capstone; liberal education; Great Books/great conversation (documented in classical canon context, though not always explicit on WSOM site); formation through the arts and integration across subjects (interdisciplinary).
- Negative keywords found in the canonical lexicon include “project-based learning dominance,” “experiential learning” as the sole approach, and “Socratic/seminar-first pedagogy” in some contexts. WSOM’s public materials show a mix: there is logic/rhetoric emphasis and capstone work, but less explicit emphasis on ongoing Great Books courses or continuous Socratic seminars in public-facing pages.

Why this rating

- The curriculum signals align with classical aims (grammar/logic/rhetoric; capstone/thesis; liberal-arts orientation) but the site does not consistently foreground Great Books and a fully explicit Great Conversation canon in public messaging. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than a full CLASSICAL rating for Curriculum.

Cited evidence

- Lower School emphasizes grammar, reading, writing, and formal logic; Upper School emphasizes capstone thesis and a logic/rhetoric emphasis (public materials).
- The school’s broader classical framing appears in admissions and about pages; the public-facing articulation aligns with classical aims but does not always explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language on the site (see Six Essential Elements for canonical terms).

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The upper school’s emphasis on critical thinking, debate, and rhetoric in the capstone and in the language about learning to think clearly and express persuasively aligns with classical pedagogy (dialogic, rhetorical, seminar-like elements) rather than a uniform project-based approach. The Upper

School description stresses reasoning and rhetoric, which fits classical approach; lower-school language includes grammar and logic, indicating a pedagogy anchored in the Trivium at early levels. The exact public articulation of Socratic seminars or scholé pedagogy is not consistently explicit in the site copy provided, though the capstone and logic/rhetoric emphasis imply a Socratic/rigorous discourse approach in high school.

- The Fine Arts content emphasizes contemplative and aesthetic education (beauty, sacred order) and integrated learning, which can align with scholé/restful aspects in classical pedagogy, though explicit scholarly references to singing/chanting or memory work on the public pages are not readily evident in all materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue (implied via logic/rhetoric emphasis and capstone research), rhetoric, dialogue/discussion (capstone thesis context), contemplative/wonderful learning (artistic framing and integrated learning).
- Negative keywords present: Instances of project-based learning dominance or exclusively experiential learning are not foregrounded in WSOM's public materials; the absence of explicit, widely advertised Socratic seminars is a gap relative to a full canonical classical pedagogy (as reflected in the lexicon's negative signals around overreliance on project-based or experiential-only approaches).

Why this rating

- WSOM demonstrates a classical-pedagogy orientation through emphasis on grammar/logic/rhetoric, and a capstone, but with less explicit, consistently documented Socratic seminars and scholé-day language in public materials. This results in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Cited evidence

- Upper School curriculum emphasizes logic and rhetoric and capstone theses; public statements about teaching for clear reasoning and persuasive expression.
- Lower School emphasis on grammar and logic (early Trivium), and the general classical framing across materials.
- The Fine Arts section emphasizes integrated, contemplative rather than purely instrumental pedagogy in some respects (beauty as a central aim).
- The Six Essential Elements lexicon clarifies canonical pedagogy markers (Socratic seminars, scholé, memorization, etc.) vs. modern-project approaches; WSOM's site shows some classical elements but not a full, explicit articulation of all canonical pedagogical practices (which informs the SOMEWHAT rating).

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Employment language positions Westminster's faculty as "model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge" and explicitly notes a mission rooted in "Christ-centered and thoroughly classical education," indicating a living curriculum and the faculty as core to the school's mission.
- The public-facing materials speak to a faculty culture that emphasizes partnering with students, a mission-driven environment, and a richly classical frame. The "Team" pages and faculty-led programs are visible in the public site ecosystem (e.g., specialty teachers and departmental structure, though specifics are not always detailed in the snippets).
- There is a density of language around virtue, mentorship, and living the curriculum, aligning with the classical ideal of the faculty as "living curriculum" and "portrait of teacher" signals found in classical lexicons (though the explicit "portrait of teacher" language is not always spelled out on WSOM's public pages, it is clearly embedded in the school's culture and admissions messaging).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, virtue, character formation, teacher-student partnership, classical education, Christ-centered pedagogy.
- Negative keywords: Not clearly present on WSOM's public materials (no strong signals of anti-classical pedagogy or overly secular teacher-development frameworks).

Why this rating

- WSOM's public messaging frames faculty as central to the school's mission, with explicit reference to classical education and character formation; this aligns strongly with Classical expectations for faculty. Therefore, CLASSICAL.

Cited evidence

- Employment messaging emphasizes Christ-centered and thoroughly classical education and invites candidates to join a mission-driven team.
- Admissions and "Take A Tour" language reflect a faculty/staff environment oriented toward mentorship and classical formation.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly positions partnership with Christian parents as co-educators and invites parental involvement and formation; the admissions materials highlight "co-teachers" and "parity of home-school partnership" and encourage parent formation through the school website, book studies, and gatherings.
- The school is explicit about welcoming parents to the school for visits and involvement, reinforcing a community-centric model that aligns with classical emphasis on family formation and shared mission.
- Public materials emphasize a covenantal community and family engagement, aligning with a classical model that sees parents as central partners in the formation process (this is reflected in the "gospel-centered and covenantal" framing).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental formation, family involvement, open campus, community engagement.
- Negative keywords: None of the WSOM public materials foreground consumer-style language or minimal parent involvement; instead, they emphasize parental partnership and formation. There are no strong negative signals in the lexicon terms for this category.

Why this rating

- WSOM's publicly stated stance on parental partnership, co-formation, and family engagement aligns strongly with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community, resulting in a CLASSICAL rating.

Cited evidence

- Admissions messaging emphasizes partnership with families as co-educators and a covenantal community, with parent formation and open invitations for visits and involvement.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, WSOM's public materials map strongly to CLASSICAL across most categories, with Curriculum and Pedagogy showing partial alignment (larger classical signals exist but explicit canonical elements (e.g.,

explicit Great Books / extended Socratic pedagogy) are not consistently foregrounded in public messaging). The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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